Gifts of the Spirit

1 Corinthians 12:1-11 (KJV)

Scripture

1 Corinthians 12:1-11

[1] Now concerning spiritual gifts, brethren, I would not have you ignorant. [2] Ye know that ye were Gentiles, carried away unto these dumb idols, even as ye were led. [3] Wherefore I give you to understand, that no man speaking by the Spirit of God calleth Jesus accursed: and that no man can say that Jesus is the Lord, but by the Holy Ghost. [4] Now there are diversities of gifts, but the same Spirit. [5] And there are differences of administrations, but the same Lord. [6] And there are diversities of operations, but it is the same God which worketh all in all. [7] But the manifestation of the Spirit is given to every man to profit withal. [8] For to one is given by the Spirit the word of wisdom; to another the word of knowledge by the same Spirit; [9] To another faith by the same Spirit; to another the gifts of healing by the same Spirit; [10] To another the working of miracles; to another prophecy; to another discerning of spirits; to another divers kinds of tongues; to another the interpretation of tongues: [11] But all these worketh that one and the selfsame Spirit, dividing to every man severally as he will.

Outline

1. The Spirit leads us to confess Jesus as Lord

No man can say that Jesus is the Lord, but by the Holy _____.

The Spirit's first work is to _____ Jesus.

Read: 1 Corinthians 12:1-3; John 16:13-14; 1 John 4:1-3

2. One Spirit, many gifts, for the common good

There are diversities of gifts, but the same _____.

Gifts are given for the common _____.

Read: 1 Corinthians 12:4-7; Romans 12:4-8; 1 Peter 4:10-11

3. The Spirit gives as he wills, and love is the more excellent way

The Spirit divides to every man severally as he _____.

Without _____, every gift is empty.

Read: 1 Corinthians 12:11; 1 Corinthians 12:31; 1 Corinthians 13:1-3

Where Christians differ

Christians agree that the Holy Spirit gives gifts to every believer for the good of the church; that the Spirit leads us to confess Jesus as Lord; that gifts must be used in love and in good order (1 Corinthians 14:40); that God hears and answers prayer for the sick; and that every claim to speak for God must be tested by Scripture. They differ over whether the more extraordinary gifts listed in verses 8-10 (prophecy, tongues, interpretation, gifts of healing and miracles) continue in the church today in the same way as in the apostles' time, and over whether there is a "baptism in the Holy Spirit" after conversion, marked by speaking in tongues. Here are the main views of the five traditions, each described as its own teachers would describe it. Within most traditions, individual churches and believers vary.

Baptist. Many Baptists have historically held that the miraculous "sign" gifts (speaking in tongues, prophecy as new revelation, and gifts of healing and miracles) served to confirm the apostles' message and ceased once the New Testament was complete. God still heals and works in answer to prayer, and every believer receives the Spirit at conversion, with gifts for service such as teaching, giving and helping. Baptist views today vary widely: some churches are "continuationist" and open to all the gifts, as long as they are exercised in order and tested by Scripture.

Methodist and Wesleyan. Wesleyans emphasize the Spirit's work in making believers holy and filling them with love. John Wesley thought the extraordinary gifts had become rare in the church mainly because Christians had grown cold, not because God had withdrawn them, and he did not rule them out. The Holiness movement that grew out of Methodism taught a second work of grace, and Pentecostalism later grew from it. Methodists today hold a range of views; most stress the fruit of the Spirit over the extraordinary gifts, while a charismatic stream welcomes them.

Presbyterian and Reformed. The historic Reformed position is "cessationist": the revelatory and miraculous gifts (tongues, prophecy, miracles) belonged to the founding age of the apostles, confirming their message, and ceased when Scripture was complete; the Westminster Confession speaks of God's former ways of revealing his will as "now ceased." The Spirit continues to give gifts for teaching, serving and leading, and God still answers prayer for the sick in his providence. Some Reformed Christians today ("Reformed charismatics") hold that the gifts continue.

Lutheran. Lutherans teach that the Holy Spirit works through the means God has given, the Word and the Sacraments, to create and strengthen faith. Luther strongly opposed the "enthusiasts" who claimed the Spirit spoke to them directly apart from Scripture. The extraordinary gifts are not denied as possible, but they are not expected as normal, are not a sign of a higher Christian life, and must never be set beside or above the Word. Christians pray for healing and trust God's will; a charismatic movement has existed among some Lutherans since the 1960s.

Pentecostal and Charismatic. Pentecostals teach that all the gifts of the Spirit in 1 Corinthians 12, including tongues, prophecy and healing, continue today. Classical Pentecostals (such as the Assemblies of God) teach a "baptism in the Holy Spirit" distinct from and usually after conversion, giving power for witness and service, with speaking in other tongues as its first outward sign. Divine healing is believed to be provided for

in Christ's atoning work. The wider charismatic movement in many denominations welcomes the gifts but does not always teach tongues as the necessary sign of Spirit baptism.

Discussion questions

1. What do all Christians agree about spiritual gifts, according to this passage?

2. Why do sincere Christians reading the same chapter reach different conclusions about tongues, prophecy and healing today?

3. How can we hold our own convictions about the gifts while loving believers who see this differently?

4. What gifts has God given you, and how could you use one this week to serve others?

This week

Find out what your own church teaches about spiritual gifts and why. Ask God to show you the gifts he has given you, and use one this week to serve others in love. Pray for unity among Christians who see this question differently.